

The Mysterious Pond

Fiction

There is a small pond in the village of Thistlebrook that nobody talks about. It sits at the edge of an old orchard, hidden behind two ancient oak trees. People who live near it walk a little faster as they pass, even in the middle of a bright summer afternoon.

Eleven-year-old Mira had heard the stories, of course. That the pond never froze in winter. That fish found in it were always perfectly still, resting on the surface as though sleeping. That the water had a faint blue glow at dusk that no one could explain.

One afternoon, curiosity finally won. Mira pushed through the gate in the orchard fence and stood at the edge of the pond. The water was still and perfectly clear. She could see straight down to the smooth grey stones at the bottom, yet the pond looked as though it went on forever.

"It's just a pond," she said aloud, trying to convince herself.

She knelt at the edge, reached out, and dipped her fingers into the water. It was warm – much warmer than it should have been. And as soon as her fingers touched the surface, the fish below began to move. Slowly at first, then faster, circling, circling, always in the same direction.

Mira pulled her hand back sharply. The fish slowed, then stopped, then lay still again.

She reached out again. The fish circled again.

"That is very strange," she whispered.

She sat at the edge of the pond for a long time, watching. Eventually, as the sun moved lower in the sky, she noticed something she hadn't seen before. Just beneath the surface, where the light caught the water at a low angle, there were faint lines – like writing. She leaned closer. Ripples distorted the letters, but she could just make out a single word.

WAIT.

Mira stood up slowly. She looked around the orchard. Nothing moved. She looked back at the pond. The word was gone.

She went home and said nothing about what she had seen. But the next morning, she was back at the gate.